

The Spanish bishop applies indirect pressure

Opening Decisions

THE IDEA

After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5, White pressures the knight that helps defend e5. The bishop's role is often long-term rather than an immediate pawn win. Black has tactical and structural ways to meet that pressure.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Following 3...a6 4.Bxc6 dxc6, a greedy 5.Nxe5 can be met by 5...Qd4, attacking the knight and e4. The apparent removal of a defender does not automatically win a clean pawn.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What lesson does the ...Qd4 reply teach?

ANSWER AND REASONING

After removing a defender, calculate the opponent's active reply instead of assuming the target is free. Opening tactics often compensate for a temporary weakness.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Pressure can be useful even when the immediate capture fails.